

weekend
wkcd



SPLISH SPLASH

Men's swimwear is having a hot boy summer, and it is no longer staying poolside **P8**

metroPLUS THE  **HINDU**

GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK



Markets before *monuments*

From Bali's supermarkets to Lucknow's attar shops, a growing tribe of Indian travellers is exploring destinations through hyperlocal food cultures

Nidhi Adlakha
nidhi.adlakha@thehindu.co.in

Karthika Ganapathy, a Chennai-based finance professional, has several culinary-focussed Google Lists on-hand. From ingredients and snacks to meats and cookware, she whips out these lists when on holiday or shares them with a travelling friend who can help her check off must-buys.

'Will travel for food' is long past just a slogan on a T-shirt, with several travellers like Karthika tailoring their itineraries solely around a region's culinary offerings. Once termed 'grocery tourism', the new hashtag is 'Shelf Discovery' with Skyscanner's Travel Trends 2026 report noting a rise in travellers exploring grocery stores to experience destinations. Travel predictions for this year by booking.com include a boom in 'Shelfie Souvenirs', or grocery finds

that replace traditional keepsakes, given that 84% of Indian travellers are open to buying design-led kitchen or pantry staples when on holiday.

Southeast Asia and West Asia are Karthika's favoured destinations. "When visiting the former, I shop for local ramen, pandan leaves that are my go-to for baking, fresh ube, and more. I have lived in West Asia for a while and still source my zaatar, dates and rose water from trusted vendors there. On holiday, I always set aside one suitcase to bring back such delicacies," she says, adding



A tourist with Detours India.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

that a road trip across Northeast India last year had her glued to local markets. “I shopped for spices like dried chillies, gondhoraj limes, greens, and bamboo shoots, and would cook in my Airbnb. I always ask my hosts for recommendations and even ask locals and chefs for suggestions for lesser-known ingredients or restaurants to visit.”

For Mumbai-based Thomas Zacharias, this way of exploring cities has always been a part of his learnings as a chef. Long before he started The Locavore – a platform that champions regional food cultures via storytelling, community events – Thomas says he was “drawn to markets because they felt like the most honest way into the food culture of a place”. “You can eat at restaurants to understand a cuisine, but if you really want to understand how a place and its people eat, you go to its markets. You look at what people are buying, what is in season, what feels abundant, what is being displayed proudly, and what is quietly disappearing.”

This learning, he says, inevitably finds its way back into how he cooks, what he writes about, and the work at The Locavore. The latter reflects in *Chef on the Road*, wherein Thomas takes small groups of travellers on journeys to explore how 'food actually lives in specific landscapes, seasons, and communities'.

**CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 6**



THE Residency
TOWERS
CHENNAI

WELCOME TO TRINITY

Designed for the way the city unwinds, offering an experience shaped by Chennai's taste and tempo – all within an aesthetic and warm setting. With jazz and blues setting the tone, and a live quartet band bringing the evenings alive, this is the city's new lounge space at The Residency Towers.

Experience the harmony at Level 1

For Reservations



trinit
SMOOTH LOUNGE

Follow us



SIR THYAGARAYA ROAD, T. NAGAR, CHENNAI.

Difa

WOMEN'S EXCLUSIVE
FASHION ACCESSORIES & FASHION JEWELLERY

Style. Elegance. Attractive

ALL TRENDING
AND VIBING

10,000+
DESIGN'S

Updated everyday

AFFORDABLE PRICES



TIMELESS BEAUTY

A variety of bracelets for every style



TIMELESS TRADITION

A variety of anklets for every style



TIMELESS ELEGANCE

A variety of classic watches for every style



HAIR ACCESSORIES

ELEVATE EVERY STYLE

A variety of hair accessories for every mood, occasion & style



WHAT MAKES US SPECIAL!

TRENDY
Always on trend

PREMIUM QUALITY
Because you deserve the best

STYLISH
Designed to make you stand out

AFFORDABLE LUXURY
Looks premium, feels perfect

PERFECT FOR EVERY YOU!
Every mood, every occasion

GIFTING IDEAS
Thoughtful, Trendy, Timeless.

#Be You
#Be Difa



VISIT OUR NEAR BY DIFA STORE.

T.NAGAR | ANNANAGAR | VELACHERY
KEELKATALAI | TAMBARAM | PERAMBUR
MOGAPPIER | AMBATTUR | PONDYCHERRY

BQ

By Difa

DESIGNER Bridal Blouses

Customised. Crafted. Celebrate You.



DESIGNER BLOUSES
Tailored to perfection.



AARI EMBROIDERY
Intricate. Timeless. Art.



DESIGNER WEAR
Crafted for your special moments.



WEDDING CUSTOMISATION
Your dream. Our design.



CELEBRATION OUTFITS
For every occasion, made memorable.

WHAT MAKES US ELEGANT!

PERSONALISED DESIGNS
Made just for you

EXPERT ARTISANS
Crafted with precision

LUXURIOUS FABRICS
Handpicked for perfection

TIMELESS ELEGANCE
Classic today, iconic forever.

PERFECT FIT
Because you deserve the best

UNFORGETTABLE OUTFITS
Made to be remembered.

Timeless Elegance.
Made For You.

Crafted with passion, just for you.



T.NAGAR

37, Sarojini Street, T.Nagar,
Chennai - 600017

T: 044 2436 3624 | M: +91 80159 11018

ANNA NAGAR

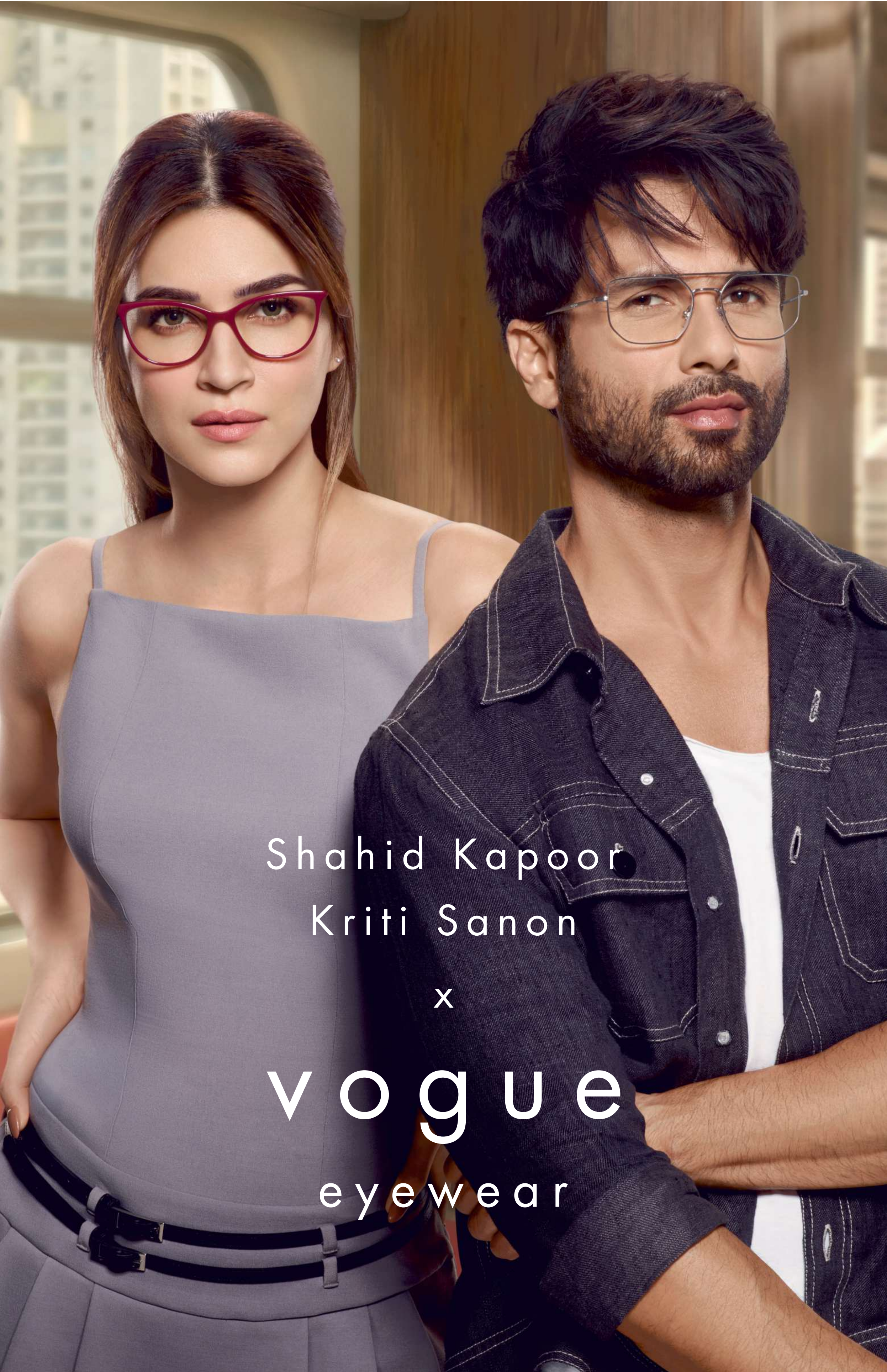
16. 4th Ave, AH Block, Shanthi Colony,
Anna Nagar, Chennai - 600040

T: 044 2622 3624 | M: +91 90425 61018



CM
YK

A



Shahid Kapoor
Kriti Sanon
x
vogue
eyewear

pick of the week



In the groove

After 18 years, Indian progressive rock band Motherjane is plugging in with its new album *Dobāreh* — and before the album drops, fans can catch a first listen at a special digital listening session at Vinyl & Brew TTK Road on May 24, 6.30pm onwards. Hosted by Aum-i Artistes, expect vinyl chatter, indie rock nostalgia, exclusive vinyl pre-orders and a celebration of one of Indian rock’s most iconic comebacks. *Tickets on fanpit.live*



Teeny tiny tales

HTC’s KidLit Pop-up brings a weekend of stories, colours and creativity with gel plate printing, fun building block techniques, storytelling sessions and hands-on art workshops led by illustrator Vaishnavi Giri, author Vaishali BK and Dira Paavai Rajavel. With over 1,000 illustrated children’s books to browse, the playful pop-up is packed with messy fun and imagination at Hindustan Trading Company, Royapettah on May 23 and 24. *Register on workshopsbyhtc.com*



Wardrobe refresh

Collage’s Sweet Summer Edit ’26 gathers contemporary labels Ayaka, StoiQUE, Shimona Agarwal, Three and Surmaye for a showcase of relaxed summer dressing. Expect breezy shirts, relaxed pants, dresses and separates alongside Surmaye’s saris and blouses, all curated for Chennai heat. *The showcase is on till today, from 11am to 7.30pm, at Collage, Rutland Gate. The collection is priced under ₹15,000.*



Summer on a plate

Fresh flavours take over at DOU Brew Room & Bakehouse with Summer Fields, a seasonal menu showcasing summer produce. Expect dishes like bay prawn and arugula salad, pizza prosciutto and grilled figs, spiced beer-braised tiger prawn and confit chicken legs alongside chilled summer salads. *Priced ₹1,800-plus for two. Available till May 31, from 8am to 10pm across DOU outlets in the city. For reservations, call 9940091849.*

(Clockwise from below) Inside Punchline; Jeet, Chef Amninder and Chirag; punch on the menu; and Iberico ice cream. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Pack a punch

With a spirited cocktail menu and easy attitude, Punchline channels Mumbai’s old-school bars through a modern lens

Dhruv Trivedi

Punchline’s air of levity promises a much-needed departure from the city’s wave of “serious” cocktail bars. The new Bandra bar with its boxy exterior, neon signage, and oversized windows evokes a 1970s American diner. The vibe here is easy — unfussy drinks inspired by punch. The five-ingredient precursor to cocktails (its name rooted in the Hindi word *paanch*) was first cobbled together by East India Company sailors to make local hooch more palatable. The bar, thankfully, does not take the liberty this writer has by springing a history lesson on you. This is the second bartender-led cocktail project by co-founders Jeet Rana, Chirag Pal, and Chef Amninder Sandhu. Barbet & Pals, which opened in late 2025 in Delhi’s GK2 market, feels inspired by their roots. Punchline is them on their day off. Early-2000s pop music wafts through the cosy space with just

the right amount of shoulder-rubbing intimacy. Every edge is rounded, the high tables are made for standing banter, and the little nooks invite conversation. Punchline is part ode, part aspirant to the Bombay bars of yore. “We’ve always wanted to do a bar in Mumbai, and it had to be in Bandra,” says Jeet. For him, Punchline is the coming together of a few different desires. “The first drink I made was in a big punch bowl,” he says. The ones at Punchline brim with technique. Both he and Chirag propose a drinking experience that is social at its core. **What you should try** Every cocktail sits on its own little flavour island. There are communal punch bowls that contain about four servings. I dutifully start with the Punchline Paradise, a fruity gin-based number softened with clarified milky oolong tea.



The Nutorious is whisky with overtones of sesame, reined in by a tangy hit of sherry. Swine & Brine anchors Punchline’s titular cocktail section — a medley of five spirits held together with a Goan chorizo infusion. The highballs begin with the T-Root Bomb, a crisp vodka-citrus mix that sparkles on the tongue thanks to akarkara root from Jeet’s

native Uttarakhand. In boozier territory sits Funk You, which blends tequila, mezcal, and lightly fermented notes of Japanese koji and strawberry. Chef Amninder takes a maximalist approach, populating the menu with her favourites. The Made Wings Great Again are tandoor-roasted and encrusted with crisp black rice. There’s the Two Good Lamb Chops with a side of marrow, and the Iberico Ice Cream flecked with crisp ham. Vegetarians will have to content themselves with the Whopped Feta with spicy cherry jam, Too Many Mushroom on sourdough, and Punchline Roast Broccoli with fermented chilli butter. Desserts contrast nicely with the Pickle Packs — a pair of frosty spirit and briny pickle juice shots that go down like a whiff of salty sea breeze. Delightfully dangerous. It remains to be seen how serious Punchline is about rising to the occasion when impromptu drinking plans take shape, because that is what your neighbourhood bar is all about.

A meal for two (with drinks) will cost around ₹3,000-plus taxes.



AT THE TABLE

Karan Gokani

Some of the most useful lessons I learnt as a young restaurateur came from New York restaurateur Danny Meyer’s book *Setting the Table*. He writes beautifully about the guest who comes in alone. Most diners come in with an agenda — to impress a date, close a deal, celebrate an anniversary or survive a family gathering. A solo guest, on the other hand, has only one agenda: a date with the restaurant. Now, restaurants are, of course, places of conversation. Viewed that way, most people are coming in to rent a table for a while. The restaurant gives them lighting, music, plates, wine and a setting in which to say things they might not say at home. It is a stage for love, gossip, awkward silences, business plans, breakups, proposals, politics and so much more. We provide the scenery, snacks and lubrication. But a solo diner is different. A

A table for one

As solo dining gains popularity globally, restaurants are beginning to view the table for one not as an inconvenience, but as an opportunity to offer a more thoughtful and attentive hospitality experience

solo diner is not just renting the room. They are there for the restaurant itself, and dining with it. When someone eats alone, their attention to detail is far more heightened than someone deep in conversation with a partner. They watch the rhythm of service, they hear the clatter from the kitchen, the couple on a first date two tables away. They read the menu thoroughly. They taste each bite intentionally. They are, in the best sense, fully present. For that reason, we have always tried to look after our solo guests particularly well at Hoppers. If a two top is available, we will seat a single diner there. We make sure someone checks in and strikes up a conversation when it is welcome, or knows when to leave them alone. Get that right, and the solo diner who felt genuinely looked after has a far higher likelihood of becoming a guest for life. As Meyer put it, treating solo diners as royalty is both the right thing to do and smart business. I have never found a reason to disagree. Solo diners are often quick. They are often curious. They are usually willing to spend on something good. If they feel seen, they come back with friends and family. Online restaurant-reservation service company *OpenTable* has reported growing interest in dining alone, especially among younger diners, and recent industry reports point to more flexible eating habits and more people treating solo meals as self care. Toast’s 2025 restaurant trends report noted a rise in solo reservations, while wider commentary has linked the trend to remote work, smaller households, later marriage, urban living, travel, social media led food discovery and the fact that people today cook at home far less than previous generations did. Anecdotaly, I think there is another reason too. Restaurants have become more casual. You no longer need a jacket, an occasion and three other people to justify eating something delicious in public. People now travel to bakeries, queue for noodles, cross

towns for pizza. In general, quality dining has become a lot more coveted and accessible. In India, I suspect the shift will take longer. Eating, especially at dinner, is still often occasion-led and involves friends and family. Eating alone is more functional — a quick thali at lunchtime, a dosa on a Sunday morning, a roll late at night or a sandwich on the way home. This is perhaps because many homes have more cooking support than in the West. In London or New York, buying ingredients, cooking, cleaning and finding the time is often less appealing than sitting at a bar with a bowl of pasta. Personally, I love eating alone and adore counter dining. On a recent long weekend in New York, where I had gone partly to watch Bruce Springsteen and partly, inevitably, to eat, I was reminded how clever a bar seat can be. The hottest restaurants, where reservations usually vanish months in advance often have a bar for walk-ins. For anyone trying to get into a new restaurant, this is often my most practical advice — “Go alone and ask nicely for the bar.” The rise of solo dining should be good for restaurants too, not only financially but philosophically. It reminds us that hospitality should not be reduced to managing covers, turning tables and squeezing in one more six top on a Friday night. At its best, a restaurant is about conversation as much as food, whether that conversation is with a waiter, a bartender, a chef at the pass, or the stranger sitting beside you. And no one is better placed to have these than the solo guest. From a restaurant’s perspective, a table for one is not an inefficiency. It is the ultimate compliment. And from a guest’s perspective, it is a very smart way to hack the booking system and know instantly which restaurants are truly in it for hospitality, not just profit. *Karan Gokani is a London-based chef and restaurateur who spends his time cooking, travelling and exploring what the world is eating. He loves the gym, biryani and his frying pan. Not necessarily in that order.*

Do cicadas sing?

Soumik Datta’s Melodies in Slow Motion shows us what climate change sounds like

Sanjana Ganesh

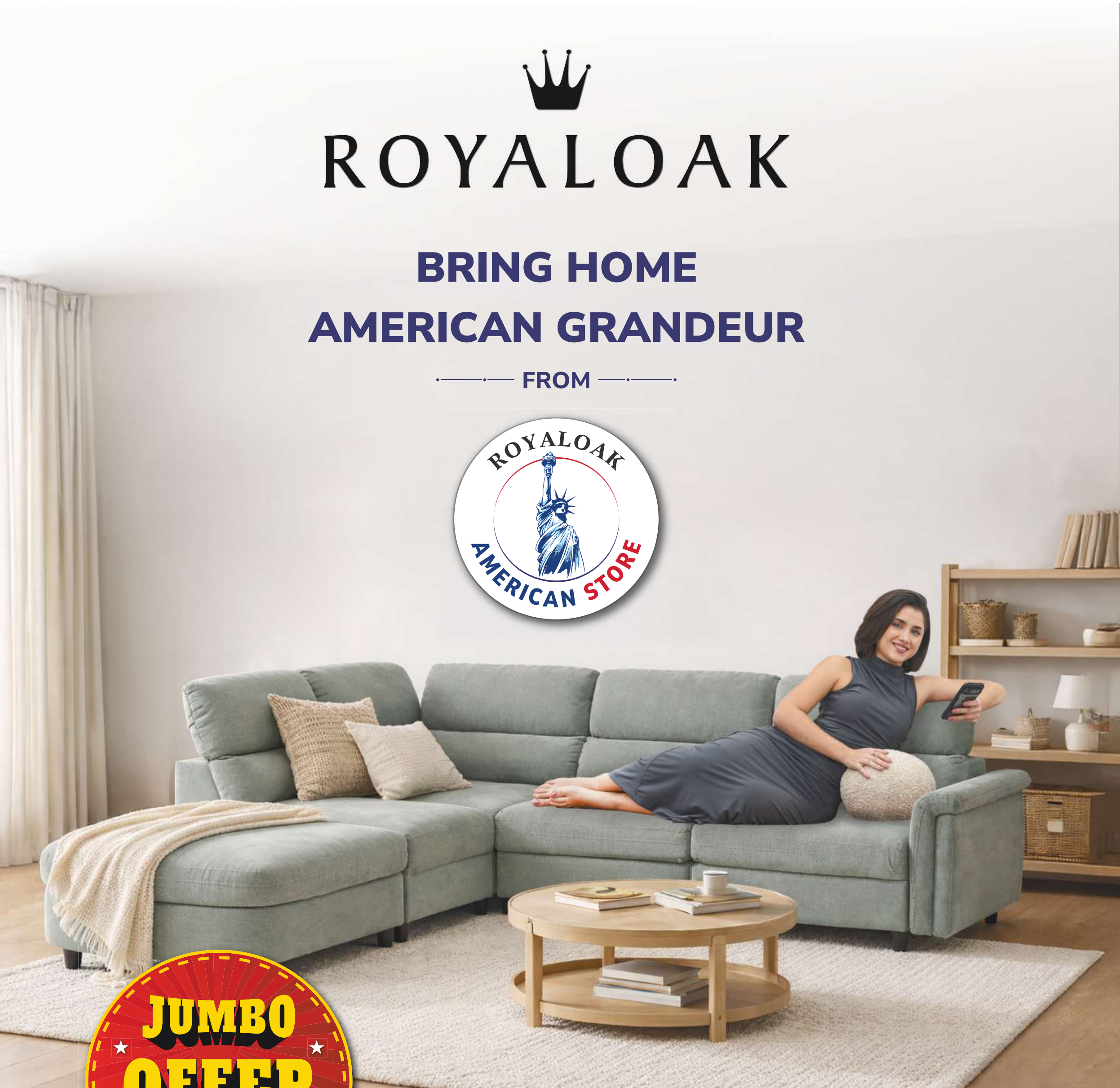
sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in

There are parts in Soumik Datta’s *Melodies In Slow Motion* show in Chennai where the audience hesitates to applaud. The intimate group of 15-something, are all wearing headphones and listening to the chirping of crickets, the trickle of crabs, and the seemingly slow mish-mash of tides between mangrove roots. Between it, come the melodies performed by Sumesh Narayanan’s percussion, Debjit Patitundi’s tabla, Sayee Rakshith’s violin, and Soumik’s own sarod. Nobody wants to disturb the sound. This is Nature we are talking about. Even breathing feels loud. “Of course,” replies Soumik, to an audience member who asks if they can clap. The audience then proceeds to show their gratitude towards the performers for this experimental journey, one that seems to interpret the waggle of bees looking for food; the rhythmic hum of cicadas; and the jubilant dance of fireflies. *Melodies In Slow Motion’s* first show in Mumbai in April was vastly different from the one here in Chennai. Soumik says, speaking to *The Hindu*. “The lines blurred between the audience and us. It was far more interactive and it felt like the audience was in the exercise.

This listening session in Chennai is an experiment for us too. The lines blur here very differently because we are seated in a circle. There is not a sound from the audience. I do not see this as a bad thing. Here, everyone is immersed and even though there is no applause, there is a warmth — evident in the silence,” he says. The show, commissioned by British Council India, was conceptualised during the pandemic. Soumik, who was in London at the time, said he heard sounds in the city that he never could before or after the lockdown was lifted. The stillness gave birth to many projects by the award-winning composer including this one where he spotlights climate change. He travelled across the country from Punjab to Puducherry, collecting shells, and the movement of leaves, crabs, barnacles, and mangroves, while sitting down to create these melodies. This show in Chennai comes at the tail-end of his tour across India, attempting to awaken a collective consciousness with bright, beautiful melodies that are gentle at first, reaching crescendos right after. “We are now playing much more sensitively to each other and to you because a space like this provides that kind of intimacy,” says Soumik, choosing to remind us to slow down, to breathe. “We don’t pay attention to these sounds on the daily,” he adds.



Soumik Datta during the performance of Melodies in Slow Motion at GSA in Mumbai. SHAUNAK GOSAVI



DISCOVER A WIDE RANGE OF
SOFAS | RECLINERS | BEDS | DINING | MATTRESSES | HOME DECOR | OFFICE & OUTDOOR FURNITURE



THE ROYALLOAK
ASSURANCE



FREE
DELIVERY



FREE
INSTALLATION



EASY
EMI

HDFC BANK GET 5%
INSTANT DISCOUNT ON HDFC BANK CARDS
SAVEIN **BAJAJ FINSERV**

FOR FRANCHISE ENQUIRY
76194 33045
81473 54313

EXCHANGE OFFER
UPTO 70% OFF
VALID IN SELECT STORES ONLY

200+
STORES ACROSS
INDIA & UAE



CHAT WITH US

VELACHERY
89519 64898

AMBATTUR
73497 83175

THIRUNINRAVUR
89519 65884

KUMANANCHAVADI
81485 06840

OMR KARAPAKKAM
63664 30536

REDHILLS
87925 13551

ECR
89519 65887

TIRUVALLUR
74115 12306

EKKATUTHANGAL
89519 66150

KALAVAKKAM
74115 12509

MUDICHUR
74115 11599

VIVIRA MALL
91486 93805

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

“This year alone, we’ve done three such trips: to Maharashtra, Mishmi Hills in Arunachal Pradesh, and to Jharkhand during the mahua harvest. In all of these, markets, farms, producers, and local food economies are central, not as sightseeing, but as a way of helping people understand food more deeply,” explains Thomas, who, after his time in the US, travelled through France, Italy, Spain, Portugal, and Japan. “Those trips were shaped almost entirely by food. I spent time in markets, bakeries, small stores, farms, and neighbourhood food spaces. That was my way of understanding a culture.”

Exploring on foot
Writer Anubhuti Krishna who also helms the experiential platform Lucknow with Anubhuti (₹15,000 per person for a two-day tour), says she has noticed an interesting shift in people travelling for food experiences. As part of a food and aromatics tour organised in Delhi and Lucknow this March, she took a group of Indian and international travellers on the Lucknow leg. “We visited attar shops, perfumeries, and organised meals that highlighted how aromatics such as clove, mace, and nutmeg are central to Lucknowi cuisine. In fact, even kebabs are infused with vetiver and sandalwood,” says Anubhuti, adding that the group was taken to local markets to shop for spices. “Guests enjoy visiting local markets to buy namkeen (dal moth, namak paras), mithais (motichoor ladoos), spices (buknu, kebab masala), and attar. In the winter, sweets like gajak and revdi are popular.”

Down South, Jayanti Rajagopalan has been hosting city and culinary tours in Hyderabad since 2008. Named Detours India, the outfit also showcases India to tourists through food. “I explore the connections between food and culture, geography, and history.” Her annual Khanasutra festival takes travellers across three-four cities, and this year it will be held in November and guests will explore Hyderabad, Puri, Amritsar, and Uttarakhand. “These tours are not just about eating, but understanding the country better. Most clients enjoy food walks (₹4,000 per person) that involve a cooking experience at a local’s home. Post this, they are keen on buying the utensils, ingredients and produce rather than packaged stuff at the airport. Popular items on their shopping lists include tiffin boxes, masala dabbas, and spices like gongura for



Markets before monuments

Thomas Zacharias looks for...

- What is local and seasonal at that moment.
- What people are actually buying and cooking, as opposed to what is simply being displayed.
- Ingredients he doesn’t recognise, or ones he recognises but hasn’t seen used in that particular way.
- The relationship between vendors and customers. In many places, food still moves through trust, memory, and habit, not just transactions.



Keep in mind

- Almost all ingredients can be carried on flights if they are checked in, but packing becomes important especially with liquids, pickles, or anything that might leak.
- In hand baggage, liquids above 100ml, along with things like pickles or spice powders and chillies, are usually not allowed.
- With perishables, it really comes down to handling. If they’re properly refrigerated beforehand and stored immediately once you arrive, they’re generally fine for shorter journeys.



which we take them to local shops,” says Jayanti, whose tours include experiences such as how tandoors are made in Amritsar, and chatting up women at an Ahmedabad cooperative on how their ability to cook is empowering in trying family situations.

The trend is picking up among hospitality majors too. For instance, at The Four Seasons in Jimbaran Bay, Bali,

A Day in the Life of a Jimbaran Fisherman tour takes guests on a seven-hour experience on a traditional boat to learn local fishing techniques. This includes a stop at the local Kedonganan Fish Market to choose ingredients to cook at the resort’s Jala Cooking Academy.

Closer home, The Lotus Palace Chettinad launched Suvaai last year: a three-day

immersive culinary festival that comprised elaborate wedding-style feasts, talks on heirloom recipes, traditional cooking methods, distinctive cookware, and more.

Anubhuti explains how this trend is evolving and now many seasoned chefs sign up for the tours to explore lesser-known delicacies. “We have hosted chef teams from restaurants within India such as Masque, and international

▶ (Clockwise from left) A child and his mother picking groceries at the farmers’ market; a chicharonnes (pork skin) vendor at Tlacolula Market in Oaxaca, Mexico; a vendor cleaning dried corn in Mexico; a vendor at Ferns Pork Centre in Margao, Goa; a banana seller in Bali; and Thomas Zacharias at a market in Dimapur, Nagaland. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK, KHAJA ZAFARULLAH AND THE LOCAVORE



discovering the jeeravan spice mix led to a bhutte ka kees-inspired dish, and tasting kalari cheese in Srinagar resulted in a fritter on the menu at The Bombay Canteen.”

Thomas says it is important not to lift something directly out of context, “but to spend time understanding it”. “If I’m trying to recreate a dish, I’ll first bring back the ingredients, figure out sourcing, and cook it as faithfully as possible. Only after that do I start interpreting or adapting it. So while the starting point is often a market or a single ingredient, what it really becomes is a longer process: of understanding, translating, and slowly building it into my own cooking.”

For Delhi-based private chef Khaja Zafarullah, also known as Zafar, his tryst with shelf discovery began by accident 25 years ago when he picked up sumac, Marash peppers, and baklava at a market in Istanbul. “After that trip, every time I went to a different country, I would go to a store or market and pick up local cheese, spices, and cured meats which I would bring back and use in my kitchen,” says Zafar, who has been on several culinary-led journeys with experts in the field. These include trips to Georgia and Thailand with cookbook

Shop smart

- Keep baggage limits in mind, and purchase ingredients that you will not get locally or online.
- For pickles and similar products that come with a risk of spillage, ask vendors if they can ship them to your home address.
- If travelling within India, most branded snacks are available online so only shop for unique finds.
- When abroad, opt for local markets rather than airport stores for a more authentic experience.

author Naomi Daguid; with British author Fuchsia Dunlop to Yunnan; to name a few.

He explains, “These trips almost always include a visit to markets or specialty stores. On some of these tours, we take cooking classes, which also give us an opportunity to learn about and bring back specialised ingredients like wagyu beef from Japan, and long pepper, fresh bay leaves, sausage and dried meat from Mehalaya.”

Some of his most interesting finds include hand-harvested fennel pollen from California that he uses sparingly on ice creams and salads, Sichuan dried meat from Yunnan, rare chilhuacle chillies found only in Oaxaca, Mexico, that Zafar uses to make mole and barbacoa.

Alongside fresh produce and dry snacks, utensils and traditional cookware also feature on the shopping lists of culinary-focussed travellers. Zafar, for example, has picked up crockery, glasses, knives, and kitchen tools from around the world. “I have a specialised truffle shaver, cheese knives specific to particular cheeses, and beautifully glazed bowls. In India, I love visiting cottage industries: weavers for tablecloths and napkins, potters for tableware.”

Pots, pans, and baking trays feature on Karthika’s Google lists. “I shop for ceramics, old Pyrex ware, crystal ware, and more. I am still on the lookout for oreshki pans (walnut cookie pans), a German obstorte (fruit flan) pan, and a cast iron waffle pan. These aren’t expensive buys, but are specific kitchenware I keep an eye out for.”

Akin to Thomas who recently picked up a mortar and pestle in Vietnam made of coconut wood. “It’s simple, but works beautifully, and carries with it a memory of where it came from. You can’t fully understand the food without understanding the vessel it is cooked in, and traditional cookware carries technique, but also memory and rhythm,” he says, adding that whether it is an earthen pot, a fermentation jar, a particular kind of pan, or even a very specific ladle, these tools shape flavour, texture, and process in ways we often overlook.

Packing woes

Getting back from a vacation with a bag full of edible souvenirs is a dream, but given current times where air fares are soaring as are freight costs, practicality comes into the picture. “The fact that almost everything is available online these days is a double whammy: on one hand it takes out the fun of experiencing a snack being made in front of you, and on the other, ordering online saves one the hassle of lugging it back home. Domestic baggage limits are a hindrance, and spillage issues as well,” says Jayanti, who prefers buying all consumables such as olive oil, saffron, and paprika from a local supermarket rather than at the airport.

If you are planning to head out on a similar culinary trail, these experts recommend taking one thing with you: an open mind. “I don’t like going with a fixed idea; I like to browse through the aisles and find unique ingredients. I was in Chiang Mai and found pineapple Kit Kat. Who knew? If you have a shopping list, fine, but take the time to browse without an agenda; you never know what you might find. It is not just about going shopping for ingredients; but understanding their stories and the history they carry,” concludes Zafar.

S Poorvaja
poorvaja.sundar@thehindu.co.in

There is an audience watching with rapt attention as Namrata Soni picks up a brush, and sweeps it across the cheeks of a model seated in front of her. 2026 marks 26 years since the celebrated make-up artiste first picked up a brush, beginning a career that has spanned films, editorial spreads, brides and weddings, co-founding makeup brand Simply Nam and teaching thousands of students through her make-up academy.

“There are very few of us in the world who find what we love to do and eventually start getting paid well for it,” she laughs. “And I feel very lucky that I wake up every day, and get to make someone feel beautiful. I think that’s very rare, and it has been incredible,” says Namrata. While Namrata’s film credits include *Om Shanti Om*, *Aisha*, and *Khoobsurat*, she is especially known for her long-standing association with actor Sonam Kapoor, having been behind several of her memorable Cannes

appearances and big fashion moments.

In Chennai, Namrata led a make-up masterclass as part of Phoenix MarketCity’s Beauty Xperience, an immersive festival for beauty brands, enthusiasts and creators earlier this month. The audience at her masterclass, and the crowds at the festival, were a clear indication; of how beauty, once relegated to the glam, glitzy and the famous, has now become a part of our everyday lives, finding its way into our homes and our handbags.

Nearly two decades on, Namrata acknowledges the rapid evolution of the beauty industry, and says that the creative landscape has undergone significant change. “The kind of shoots we used to do, the events, the make-up and hair...everything was so different. In the past, everybody was willing to experiment and try something new. Now, with social media playing such a huge factor and people having so many opinions, I think people have gotten very scared of what they want to try and choose to play it safe. I can probably



Blush hour

Celebrity make-up artist Namrata Soni reflects on changing beauty trends, her upcoming mascara launch, and why Indian eyes deserve more kajal

think of a couple of people who maybe want to do something different, that too only if it is photographed well,” she says.

While she has consciously

chosen to step back from films, Namrata says she has her hands and schedule full with brides (she is gearing up to jet set to Lake Como for a wedding soon), masterclasses

▶ Namrata Soni during a masterclass at Beauty Xperience, Chennai. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

at her make-up academy, and working on new products for her make-up brand Simply Nam.

After working on over 15,000 faces across a 21-year career as a make-up artiste, Namrata says it felt only natural to launch her own brand in 2021, with Hanna Strömgren Khan, who incidentally was one of her brides.

“As a make-up artiste, I realised we were always looking to the West to pick up products. When I started this brand, I was very clear that I want to make something that works for our climate, our tones, and our skin color in India,” Namrata says.

Their upcoming launch, a mascara, is one that has her immensely excited. “It is very special,

and perfect for our country,” she says.

Moodboard musings

With an increasing number of brides making a beeline for celebrity make-up artists for their big day, it isn’t uncommon to see clients walk in armed with celebrity references, eager to recreate popular make-up looks. Pinterest references and Instagram reels can create an avalanche of inspiration, of course, but Namrata says that while they can serve as useful references, it is also important to set realistic expectations.

“It is good to have an opinion, but remember to trust your make-up artiste. It is also important that you choose a make-up artiste who specialises in the kind of make-up you want; be it light, soft, dewy or bold,” she adds.

We ask her about her favourite make-up trends for 2026, and something that she thinks

needs to retire. Referencing the ongoing Cannes Film Festival’s red carpet appearances, Namrata says she loves glowy make-up. “Skin looks like skin, and I think that is great. I am however not loving the very cakey, powdery make-up that seems to be catching on these days,” she says.

She also points to how eye make-up has increasingly become boring and dull. “As Indians, we have beautiful eyes. Where is the *kajal*... and where are the liners? When you represent India on the red carpet, I would expect to see people play around with this and make their eyes stand out even more.”

Namrata harkens back to the Cannes red carpet in 2013, and brings up a look she created for Sonam Kapoor which she ranks among her top favourites through her career.

“We did a gorgeous liner and a berry lip. And she was wearing a beautiful Anamika Khanna sari with a *nath* in her nose. The look embodied India on the red carpet for me, and over a decade later, people still bring it up,” she smiles.

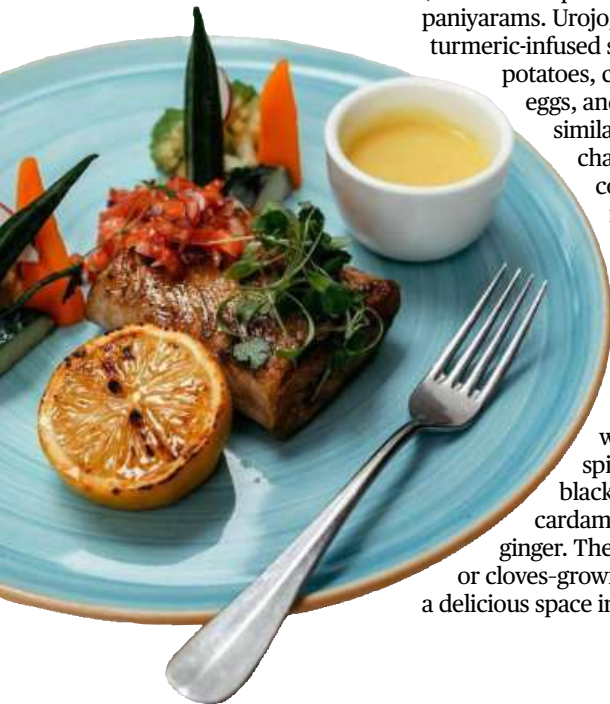


Tejashee Kashyap

It has been just a few hours since my friend and I landed in the archipelago of Zanzibar, off the coast of mainland Tanzania. The people here are disarmingly sweet, greeting you multiple times a day, often followed by the ever-present Swahili expression, “Hakuna Matata”. The warm hospitality, smiles, and the occasional Hindi phrase, *kaise ho aap* (how are you?), once they learn you are from India. It all reaffirms their deep-rooted connection with the country. And as the days stretched, from two to a full week, I realised that the Indian influence here is anything but subtle.

India on a Zanzibari plate
Zanzibar’s coastline looks even more stunning under the moody skies. Overlooking the pouring rain from The Dining Room restaurant at The Residence Zanzibar resort, my eyes immediately drift to the local section of the menu – Swahili chapatti, pilau, sambusa – all of it strikingly similar to Indian fare. It was a moment of culinary déjà vu.
Curious, I ordered the Zanzibari pilau and sambusa. What arrived was a fragrant, warming bowl of long-grain rice cooked with spices, meat, and the occasional vegetable, similar to our *pulao*. But the Swahili signature was distinct – earthy spices, like black pepper, cinnamon, cardamom, cloves, a subtle smokiness in the flavour with caramelised onions. Sambusas were pocket-sized, less crisp, slightly soggy, and filled with spiced meat, unlike our *samosas*. Different, yet familiar.

In the later days of my time there, I found myself sampling local cuisine. A laidback morning stroll along the beaches of Paje and Jambiani often



(Clockwise from left) Seafood platter; Swahili flavoured grilled prawns; chicken pilau; and grilled fish fillet. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Most Indians were traders who established shipping links and, inevitably, brought with them the taste of home. Yet, often overlooked in these histories, they helped push Zanzibar to the world stage – not just economically, but culinarily – introducing curries, chapati, biryani,

Namaste, Zanzibar!

From chapatis and pilau to sambusas and spice-laden curries, the island’s cuisine carries the imprint of centuries of trade, migration and cultural exchange with India

led me to small shops selling maandazi, what Swahilis mostly have for breakfast – a fried bread – like Mangalorean buns. Vitumbua (coconut rice pancakes) are like paniyarams. Urojo, a tangy, turmeric-infused soup loaded with potatoes, crisp bhajis, boiled eggs, and raw mango, is similar to the flavours of chaat, though in a comforting, soupy form.
The curries too were thick, rich, and deeply aromatic – much like our own – with coconut milk forming the base with a heady mix of spices like cumin, black pepper, cardamom, turmeric and ginger. The mainstay, *karafuu* or cloves-grown abundantly finds a delicious space in most of the

curries. The best places to sample evening street food and soak in local flavours are Forodhani Gardens and Darajani Market in Stone Town.
Like us, Swahili people cannot imagine their dishes without spice – though our tolerance might just exceed theirs. “How spicy do you like it?” I’m asked during a cooking class led by Aisah, a sous chef at at LUX* Marijani Resort. “Add more, always more!” I reply with a grin. Aisah laughs, clearly recognising our shared love for spice-laden dishes.
Perhaps the best way to experience Zanzibar’s traditional food culture is through a cooking class. Back at the open-air kitchen, I roll up my sleeves, ready to learn and dig into the homely spread we were about to prepare – Swahili prawn curry, mchicha (shredded spinach in coconut milk), maharage (red beans in coconut milk), and fluffy Swahili chapattis. “It’s all about bold spices, fresh seafood, and coconut –ingredients that reflect the island’s

history as a trading hub,” Aisah explains.
This spice-filled cuisine has the familiar warmth of Indian flavours while still keeping its own unique identity. Today, Zanzibar may be known for its white-sand beaches and laid-back vibe. But its culinary history has a deeper story – one shaped by the dark period of slave trade and by the many merchants and travellers who passed through its shores.
Cooking across cultures
Food often outlives empires, and Zanzibar’s cuisine proves that. The Portuguese came in the 15th Century, then lost control to the Omani sultans, who transformed Zanzibar into a trading hub. While the Omanis held political power, Indian merchants left a lasting mark on the island’s food culture through their spices. Back then, spices were so valuable that they were treated like currency, worth even more than gold.

Priyadarshini Paitandy
priyadarshini.p@thehindu.co.in

It is 4pm, but the party is already underway at The Passport Hotel. I step out of my room as guests check-in, sipping on their welcome cocktail – Cherry Bomb, a pink gin drink with sour cherry, vanilla, and sparkling wine.
I head to Mini Bar, the hotel’s lobby bar and restaurant, where bartenders are in lab mode. In a small cauldron, milk simmers with pandan leaves, the scent wafting through the space, before it gets shaken into a cocktail.
“The idea for The Passport Hotel came from years of travelling across New York, London, and parts of Europe where the lobby feels alive; and the bar is the social heart of the hotel,” says Ashesh L Sajnani, founder, The Passport Hotel.
Ashesh says he wanted to create something rooted in Goa’s evolving cocktail culture. The idea was simple: build a place where the experience starts the second you walk through the door.
Back in my room, my jacuzzi is waiting, but the hotel has other plans. A cocktail station is set up in my balcony, featuring professional equipment along with seven little bottles of pre-batched signature cocktails. There is a QR code with a module on how to build these drinks. And a bartender on hand to make sure I get it right.
“Are you ready for the masterclass?” asks Gaurav, the bartender. He takes me through the the concept of pre-batching, flavours, and new techniques. “Most of the ingredients are made in-house,” he says pointing to the Turkish Delight which accompanies my drink, Meloni, that has a Bourbon base. “This was made with melons. We also made melon olio. We believe in sustainability and use all the parts of the fruits



(Clockwise from left) The rooftop pool at the hotel; Stoned Pig bar; a melon cocktail at Mini Bar; and beach vibes at Slow Tide. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



The cocktail concierge

Forget room service. This Goa hotel wants guests to collect cocktail stamps across the State before returning for a drink on the house

possible,” he explains.
Cafe Noir (coffee macerated rum in in-house cola syrup) is served with a delicious lemon curd with cookie dust. I enjoy the Hot Sauce Gibson (Martini with house-fermented jalapeno brine) even though it sets my palate on fire. To balance the heat, the garnish is a salted biscuit with pickled jalapeno, crumbled feta, mustard and curry leaf.
This is a “cocktail-forward” hotel, I am told. It means cocktail culture shapes the entire hospitality experience, explains Ashesh. “Most hotels try to keep guests inside the property. We wanted to create a hotel that uses cocktail culture to send guests deeper into Goa.”
A little green passport booklet is handed to me with my photograph on it for the evening. The challenge is to visit all the eight bars listed on

it and get a stamped seal from each. The reward? A cocktail on the house once I get back to the hotel. The list includes some of Goa’s most popular spaces, including The Second House, Drop Dead Sexy, Juna, Hideaway, Boilermaker, and Slow Tide.
Discover Goa’s different moods
“We selected bars that genuinely represent the evolving cocktail culture of Goa. It wasn’t about popularity alone, it was about identity, consistency, storytelling, and people who are pushing the industry forward in their own way,” he says, adding, “We wanted guests to discover different moods and atmospheres across Goa.”
My first stop is Slow Tide for sundowners where I try the refreshing The Who – Flor de Cana, yoghurt, washed pandan,

pineapple soda – served with a miniature cone and salted caramel. I also make a pit stop at trendy Stoned Pig, which opened recently at Slow Tide. The chatty bartenders offer great suggestions on ways to explore Goa. Though this bar is not yet in the booklet, they put a sticker in so I remember the good time I had here.
Dinner is at Hosa in Siolim. Helmed by Chef Harish Rao, this modern South Indian restaurant goes beyond the usual idli, sambar, and rasam. Here, you find curry leaf pesto snapper, mushroom pongal and even an aubergine steak with ghee rice.
Back in my room, I sleep like a log and wake up fresh with no sign of a hangover. The Passport Hotel makes a mean Ros omelette with poi. I follow it with a delicious Tiramisu latte at Cafe Saint Cloud in



Sangolda.(I confess that I also order the Turkish eggs, which are by far the best I have had, and a side of Belgian chocolate salted caramel tart.) Then to offset the guilt I walk around Assagao, admiring its lovely villas with names like Giulietta, Casa Ferrazzi, and House of Arches among others. At some points, it does not feel like Goa, nor does it feel like this century.
Back at the hotel, I indulge in an afternoon nap that the Goans refer to as *matshe aad podta*, then cool off with a quick swim on the

rooftop infinity pool that overlooks distant hills and Assagao’s greenery.
I remind myself of the mission at hand: bar hopping with my little green book. The cab situation in Goa, as we know, is a mess. As I try to figure out the logistics, the general manager of the hotel offers to drop me off at my destination. He recommends Pablo’s Bar.
Pablo’s, housed in what looks like a little cottage with a tiled roof, does not have swanky interiors or fancy cocktails but serves delightful meads, infused feni and fun snacks – think poi garlic bread, southern fried chicken, chorizo chilli fry. The killer chilled vibe ensures I settle here for the rest of the night, under the tungsten bulbs, and a sky twinkling with stars.
Tariffs start at ₹5,000.
The Passport Hotel is located at Assagao, Mapusa, Goa.

The writer was in Goa on invitation of The Passport Hotel.

What lies beneath?

Tailored, tactile and travel-ready, India's new wave of men's swimwear is redefining masculinity, one side-adjusted short at a time



Barry Rodgers
barry.nathaniel@thehindu.co.in

Once an afterthought relegated to beach bags, men's swimwear is now being recast as a wardrobe essential, thanks to a cohort of homegrown designers reimagining what it means to dress for the water. Estimates vary widely depending on how the category is defined, but reports peg India's sports and swimwear segment at under \$2 billion, around ₹200 crore (as per insights company Introspective Market Research), broader industry data suggests the sportswear market alone runs into tens of billions, according to research firm Euromonitor International. There is also a noticeable shift towards performance-oriented swimwear, featuring quick-drying and moisture-wicking fabrics. Styles like trunks, board shorts, and jammers are gaining popularity due to their versatility and comfort. This shift is driven, in part, by increased travel. In 2025 alone,

Indians clocked over 32 million trips abroad, continuing a steady upward climb, according to the Ministry of Tourism. More travel means more time spent by pools, beaches, and resort bars. And with that, a growing demand for swimwear that can keep up. "If you wear a product, you want to feel confident," says Sanket Shingare, founder of Mumbai-based men's innerwear brand, Erobold. "Traditionally, swimwear for men has been one-size-fits-all. We wanted to challenge that." His Half Swim Band line, constructed from high-grade nylon and finished with metal accents, is designed for men who want a swim trunk that does more than perform. He adds that the brand's most consistent feedback is that their trunks help men feel "sexy but not exposed" and, in some cases, even accommodate medical conditions like hernia, an unexpected layer of functionality. Over at House of Malabaar, a Mumbai-based resort wear brand, co-founder Krishna Kilachand sees swimwear as a gateway to a larger emotional shift. "Post-Covid, people want to enjoy the little moments like



taking a swim and lounging. Swimwear is no longer just about the poolside, it is about a state of mind," he says. With fabrics sourced from South Korea, the brand prides itself on high-quality finishes, comfort-first mesh lining, and silhouettes that are as travel-ready as they are tailored. The design language here is unmistakably international: subtle prints, buttery-soft mesh, side adjusters and drawstring options

tailored to different body types and levels of modesty. "We offer plus-two length on any size," says Krishna. "So if you're 6'3" and want more knee coverage, we make that happen." **Summer dress code** Delhi's Shivan & Narresh, are seeing an uptick in demand for men's swimwear that is fashion-forward yet practical. "In the past, their (men) choices were largely driven by utility, often leaning towards performance-focussed sportswear brands. Today, there is a growing openness to fashion-forward swimwear, especially on holiday. Men want to ensure their choices reflect both the vibe of the getaway and a sense of personal style," says co-founder Narresh Kukreja. "Co-ord sets are particularly popular, but resort shirts continue to see consistent demand throughout the year," he adds. Hyderabad, interestingly, leads the pack in menswear

(Clockwise from left) Sarah & Sandeep x House of Malabaar; House of Malabaar trunks; Shivan & Narresh; and, trunks from Rey&I. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



sales, says Narresh, signalling a wider regional shift in fashion appetite. "The men there are not just well-travelled, but also increasingly style-conscious and open to experimenting with fashion, whether it's bold prints, modern cuts, or elevated resortwear," Narresh adds. The brand has also seen a noticeable spike in demand linked to destination travel. "As more people plan getaways, there's a natural uptick in purchases – from statement shirts to stylish co-ord sets. But beyond travel, gifting plays a significant role too. Our shirts and polos have become go-to gifts, especially from women buying for the men." Looking ahead, Narresh sees the men's holiday wear category evolving rapidly. "We're seeing the barriers of niche appeal and limited consumption break down, as men across the country become more open

to experimenting. It's no longer just about basic denim and T-shirts." Mumbai-based entrepreneur and host of The Plush Podcast, Rahul Jagtiani, who has been swimming at the city's Cricket Club of India since he was in Class III and still makes time for a weekly swim, says his approach to swimwear has evolved to prioritise ease over excess. "Functionality and comfort matter the most," he says, adding, "I don't worry too much about aesthetics. I believe a fit body can carry off most styles effortlessly." While he keeps things practical, he does play with variety through "different prints, cuts, and lengths". A homegrown label that recently stood out to him is Rey&I, founded by Delhi-based Nishant Singhal. "They sent me a beautiful printed pair that was hand-painted by an Afghan refugee artist. The storytelling stayed with me; it's a pair I wear often," says Rahul. The collection he is referring to is called Plaj, launched in November last year and created with Afghan artist Fatima Farhad. It translates her intricate watercolour works – rooted in traditional Afghan motifs and miniature art – into contemporary swimwear. Their Kala collection, launched a month before Plaj, draws from Indian craft traditions, including Gond art (Madhya Pradesh), Warli art (indigenous folk art from Maharashtra) and pichwai (Rajasthan). Where does swimwear fall short for Indian men? In Rahul's view, it comes down to awareness. "There's a lack of understanding of what suits your body type," he says, adding, "If you're not confident in your body, avoid tiny briefs like Speedos; instead, opt for slightly longer lengths." Mumbai-based bespoke tailoring brand SS Homme, helmed by Sarah Shaikh and Sandeep Gonsalves, collaborated with House of Malabaar last year, with pieces still available on their respective websites, exemplifying this shift. The collection, priced from ₹12,000 for off-the-rack styles and ₹20,000 for bespoke creations, is lightweight and fast-drying. Design-wise, the swimwear integrates Sarah & Sandeep's signature tailoring codes with House of Malabaar's tropical eccentricity. "A good pair of swim shorts with side adjusters can work with a shirt in. Throw on a blazer, and you're ready for dinner," says Sandeep. It's safe to say new-age swimwear is doubling up as a style statement too.

Founders of Nicobar, Simran Lal and Raul Rai talk about the lifestyle brand's 10-year journey and the next chapter that includes Rajesh Pratap Singh

A decade of ease

Rosella Stephen
rosella.s@thehindu.co.in

I am seated next to the OG Anita Lal, under flowering mango trees, as she sings along with the band and is word perfect through Tina Turner's 1984 hit 'What's Love Got to Do With It'. Hand-crafted wooden toucans from the Nilgiris flash from the branches, and models navigate the former nursery, its pathways briefly repurposed as a runway. The place is packed but intimate, as some of the country's leading designers, industrialists, actors, and friends of the family celebrate Nicobar's 10-year journey under the umbrella of Eicher Goodearth. While Simran Lal shares her mother's joie de vivre, Nicobar's trajectory is distinct from that of Anita's heritage luxury brand, Good Earth: expansion is on the cards for the younger label and the vibe is relaxed. At the party in Tulsi Farms on the outskirts of Delhi, almost every guest arrived wearing or carrying something beloved from an older Nicobar collection (for actor and biker queen Gul Panag it was the classic black knotted Nicobar dress styled with an intricate phulkari stole from 1469 Original). With over 30 retail locations, strong e-commerce, and a revenue of ₹200 crore for FY 2025-26, husband-wife duo Simran Lal and

Rai clearly know what they are about. Raul commends their close-knit team and how when they launched the brand in 2016 with a black and white collection, critics scoffed that they "wouldn't last longer than a Mumbai monsoon". He recalls his first Rajesh Pratap Singh (RPS) bandhgala after years of renting tuxes in the US in his previous job as an investment banker. Now with their much-anticipated 2026 collaboration with the same Indian designer known for his precise,



Simran's reading list

Land of the Seven Rivers by Sanjeev Sanyal
Indica- A Deep Natural History of the Indian Subcontinent by Pranay Lal
The Golden Road by William Dalrymple

almost architectural construction. It seems the Nicobar family has truly come full circle. I speak to the couple about the new collection, the shimmer that was unexpected for a brand that usually avoids overtly



(Clockwise from left) Accessories from Nicobar; Rajesh Pratap Singh; founders of Nicobar, husband-and-wife duo Simran Lal and Raul Rai; and models in RPS menswear and Nicobar womenswear. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



the Nicobar way. There must be a certain subtlety, while there is the glamour. And Aparna Chandra (co-creative director) is a queen of that. Growing up, I used to wear very simple Anokhi garments and Kolhapuri chappals, while many of my friends went to designers. My only 'designer' was Aparna Chandra. She was a friend and she had that cool factor without it being over the top. **Q: The Rajesh Pratap Singh limited edition of shirts, jackets and jodhpurs is crafted in breathable cottons, indigo denims and linens, with signature graded pin tucks, and kantha stitches. Was that your brief?** **Raul:** The brief was simple: we trust you, now show us what you see. We asked Rajesh to work closely with our co-creative director Aparna Chandra to understand the Nicobar design language, but beyond that, the creative freedom was entirely his. What made it work was that we weren't starting from opposing positions. Rajesh's precision and rigour met our ease and softness and the result was something neither of us would have arrived at alone. **Q: The new NicoBaraat or the wedding collection is light and refreshing, especially with the prints,**

the colours and mix and match options. I can imagine young brides opting for them, and friends of the bride. **Simran:** Nowadays with the wedding becoming so OTT, all these poor brides look so weighed down by their lehengas. But things are changing; young girls are quite independent and have their own personality. And I think, why not? I am a big traditionalist. But if everyone's doing pastel, we're going to the other end, with roses and big dots. We used to wear our mother's Benaras sari or a Kanjeevaram sari in the past, not these heavy Swarovski outfits with the bride and groom in one colour! At Nicobar, we go back to our roots across categories, even for the home, with the roti box, or a ghee pot, or the masala box. We provide a contemporary solution. **Q: You have a background in archaeology and architecture and you study the Vedas. How do these interests find their way to Nicobar?** **Simran:** There are these books that I like to give everybody who joins the the creative team and one of them is *The Ocean of Churn: How the Indian Ocean Shaped Human History* by Sanjeev Sanyal. I spend my mornings studying. The design teams come over, and I have loads of design books. We open them up and go on beautiful design journeys, in our minds, in our hearts, and on our boards. That's actually the exciting part, no? **Q: Raul, in addition to the gifting concierge, I hear there are expansion plans. Is Dubai next?** **A:** Our immediate focus is deepening our presence in India, across metros and in Tier-1 and select Tier-2 cities. International markets are genuinely on our radar and we'd love to take Nicobar to Dubai and beyond, but we'd rather do it with the right partner than quickly. Speed has never really been our thing. **The Rajesh Pratap Singh x Nicobar special edition is priced between ₹8,000 and ₹25,000.**



France) decision to use their red-carpet slots for their own exposure.

The company makes snappy, viral videos for the Instagram and boosts its India market through Cannes Film Festival. They select influencers through intermediaries, who in turn get brands to pay them for the appearance and make content, of which *Brut India* takes a cut. The influencers are flown down by *Brut* and the red-carpet experience – from entry ticket to film screening – is made available to them.

Disha Madan, a Bangalore-based social media influencer and actor says she is baffled by the online hate. “It’s strange because I’ve only been getting love from people here,” she says after her red-carpet appearance for the Out of Competition French film *Karma*. “I’ve lost count of the number of people who asked to take pictures with me because of what I’m wearing, not because of who I am,” she adds.

For aspiring artistes who cut their teeth in social media influencing, positioning themselves as an actor is a constant challenge. Disha says she is hoping her Cannes appearance will help bridge the gap.

But the exposure may be just a thorny issue among filmmakers who view an appearance on the Cannes red-carpet as undeserving. “It’s sad to see how people are misusing the festival just to get some false press coverage back home and some form of validation,” filmmaker and producer Honey Trehan says.

Nevertheless, brands and influencers have spotted an opportunity for global exposure at a film festival that promotes artistic excellence. As long as fans and critics equate a red-carpet appearance with participation in the festival, the conversation is unlikely to die down, and the trend itself might fade but will not disappear.

However, as Honey says, “Cannes isn’t a fashion show. I don’t find this parade of influencers on the red-carpet normal.”

Prathap Nair

The 79th edition of the Cannes Film festival at the French Rivera last week was characterised by the absence of major Hollywood names and studio movies. The festival received entries for 2,541 feature films from across the world, including Russia, Spain, France, Germany, Japan and Korea. The films tackle themes as broad as French Nazi resistance, writer’s block, and sanguine meditation on life with humanoid robots.

India had to contend without a significant line-up at the festival except for the restored Malayalam classic *Amma Ariyan* by John Abraham in the classics section and the short film *Shadows of the Moonless Nights* by Mehar Malhotra in the competition section. *Amma Ariyan* is painstakingly restored by Shivendra Singh Dungarpur’s Film Heritage Foundation and had its editor Bina Paul and lead Joy Mathew at its screening.

Brand width

What India lacks in films, it made up for its presence on the red carpet. As many as 10 influencers have either walked the red carpet already or are getting ready for it.

This has naturally caused some disproportionate outrage on X (formerly Twitter) and Reddit film critiquing ecosystem, over the fact that deserving artistes from the Indian film industry are being

Lights, camera, influencer

As Indian digital creators become more visible than Indian cinema at Cannes, a debate is raging over who belongs on the red carpet – and who gets to decide

elbowed out by social media influencers. “In India, the obsession with Cannes is only to walk the red carpet,” festival regular, Indian filmmaker and actor Anurag Kashyap told a social media film reviewer, adding to the debate. “They don’t understand that the purpose of it is beyond the red carpet.”

The outrage perhaps belies people’s understanding of the red-carpet politics in Cannes and film festivals elsewhere.

Red-carpet slots are like prime-time TV slots allotted to brands and media organisations, with freelance photographers. Brands ranging from make-up and skincare giants L’Oréal and Pond’s India (Unilever) to coffee-machine manufacturer Nespresso and

jeweller Amama are free to use as they please to increase their exposure.

“It seems to me that there is a marked increase in the focus of the business side of things on the red carpet. The influx of influencers from India is perhaps a result of that,” says long-time Cannes visitor and Hindi language movie critic Pragya Mishra. “More catchy social media people equals more eyeballs for brands. It’s simply brand publicity and business, no relation to art or movies.”

Positioning influence

Indian social media influencers on the Cannes red carpet is a recent phenomenon, only three years old, when a cohort of influencers including Dolly Singh, Kusha Kapila



and Ranveer Allahbadia descended upon the French Rivera in 2023. Although with so much negative press and social media, brands tightening their purse strings due to economic reasons, it might appear the trend has already peaked.

“The whole ethos behind going to Cannes is because we all love global exposure,” says a Mumbai-based veteran publicist, who works with influencers and desired to remain unnamed. “Visibility in film festivals is a major part of any creator’s dream – networking in afterparties and filmmarkets is one way of doing it. Walking the red-carpet is another way of doing it. Cannes has received this reputation of being a Met-gala type event,” the publicist adds.

The roots of Indian influencers on the red carpet could be traced back to digital video publishers *Brut India*’s (a subsidiary of *Brut*

(Clockwise from top left) The red carpet at Cannes; Shivendra Singh Dungarpur, editor Bina Paul and actor Joy Mathew arrive for the *Amma Ariyan* film screening; a still from *Shadows Of The Moonless Nights*; and Disha Madan. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

JOCKEY
FACTORY SECONDS
UPTO 50% OFF*

*T & C apply

• 10 am to 8 pm • Open All Days • Master / Visa Card Accepted
ONLY LEISUREWEAR, ACTIVEWEAR, KIDSWEAR, THERMALS & SOCKS

Venue In Chennai
Cathedral Road

Dass Community Hall
No.55, Opp. Maris Hotel - 600 086
Org. by Surya Agency Pvt. Ltd.

Fashion forward

Label Kaleido's latest collection, Ezhaar, explores occasionwear through a lens of glamour and craft-forward storytelling. Designed by Priyanka Munot Rai, the collection blends fluid drapes, intricate embroidery and

French trompe-l'œil detailing with contemporary silhouettes. Featuring lehengas, kurta sets, anarkalis and salwars, the collection is rooted in ideas of longevity and slow craftsmanship. Ezhaar collection reflects a growing shift toward emotionally resonant fashion. *The collection is priced between ₹8,000 and ₹78,000, and is available via labelkaleido.com.*

What's new for Chennai shoppers?

Miraggio has stepped into offline retail with its first standalone experiential store at VR Mall, Anna Nagar. The store features muted tones, curved displays, and soft lighting, creating a easy-to-browse space. Shoppers can explore Miraggio's range of handbags and accessories across work, travel, and everyday styles in a more tactile setting. Built as an extension of its digital-first journey, the Chennai store marks the beginning of a larger retail expansion, with over 10 stores planned across key Indian cities this financial year.

ARCHITECTURE, BUILD & INTERIOR DESIGN EXPO

OPENS TODAY
FREE ENTRY

SPECTA
QUARTZ SURFACES PRESENTS
ACE REFLECT
POWERED BY
HAVELLS

23•24 MAY 2026
TIME: 10:00 AM - 7:00PM
CHENNAI TRADE CENTRE

VISITORS BELOW 16 YEARS ARE NOT PERMITTED

SCAN QR TO REGISTER

—SUPPORTED BY—

VISITORS BELOW 16 YEARS ARE NOT PERMITTED | **BUSINESS EVENT FORMAL ATTIRE MANDATORY** | **ace** | **ABEC** | www.acerreflect.com

An All-New Expedition to the South

New dishes, bold Southern flavours, and classics reimagined, now on Malgudi's all-new menu.

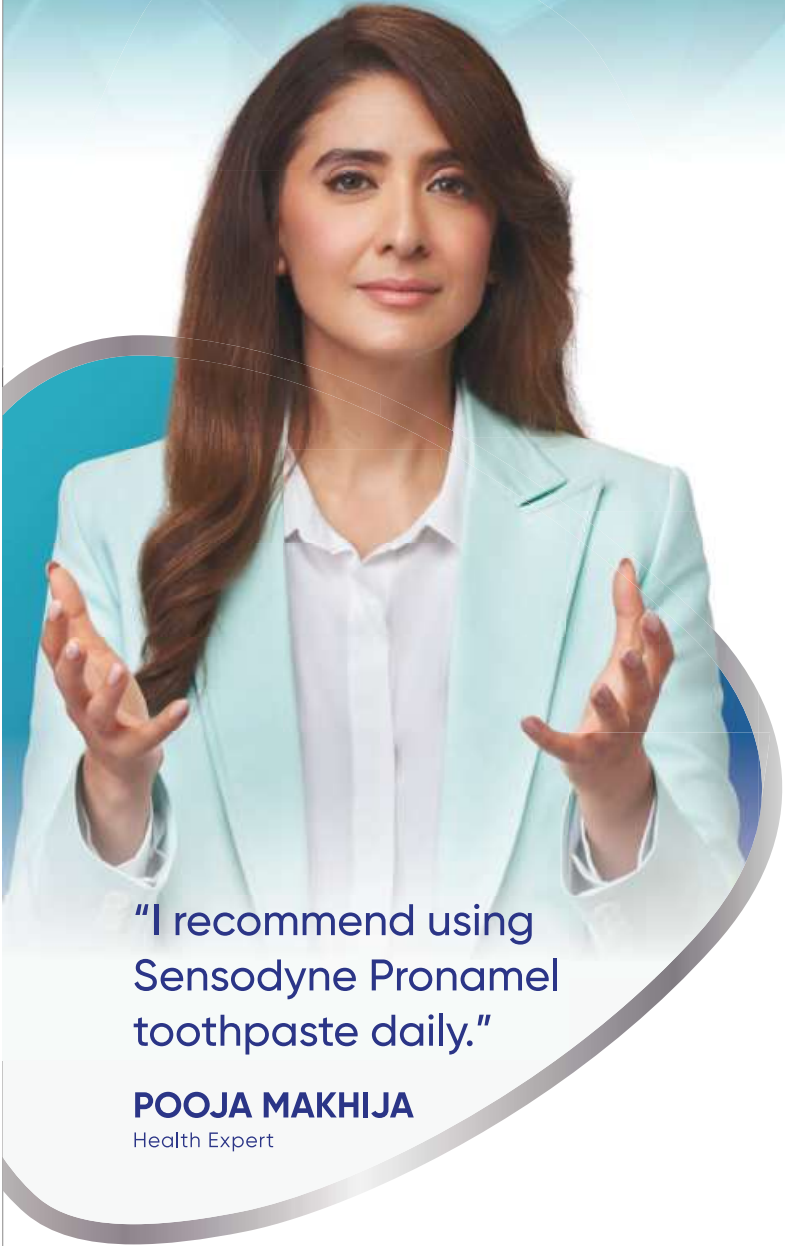
Lunch & Dinner | à la carte

For reservations, call 9840981591

SAVERA HOTEL, 146, Dr. Radhakrishnan Road, Chennai 600004 | T: 2814700 | [/ Saverahotel](https://www.saverahotel.com)

CM YK

A



"I recommend using Sensodyne Pronamel toothpaste daily."

POOJA MAKHIJA
Health Expert



"ACIDS IN EVERYDAY FOODS AND DRINKS DAMAGE YOUR TOOTH ENAMEL"



CITRUS FRUITS



TEA / COFFEE



COLA

Good oral health starts with a strong enamel, the outer protective layer of our teeth. But acids in food and drinks weaken it every day. Once your enamel is gone, you can get dental problems like Sensitivity, Yellowing and Cavities.



SENSITIVITY



YELLOWING



CAVITIES

Backed by over 20 years of research, Sensodyne Pronamel's advanced scientific formula helps absorb minerals deep into the enamel, to give you stronger enamel protection.



STRONGER ENAMEL PROTECTION*



Creative visualisation. *Fluoride strengthens enamel by promoting remineralisation and inhibiting demineralisation. Featherstone, J.D. (1999) In an in vitro lab test vs mouth's natural defense (Data on file). PMID: 10086924. © 2025 Haleon Group of Companies. Trademarks are owned by or licensed to the Haleon Group of Companies. All rights reserved. Zero, Domenick T, and Adrian Lussi (2005). PMID: 16167607. Lussi, A, and T. Jaeggi (2008). PMID: 18228059. Tahmassebi, J F et al (2014). PMID: 24072423. PM-IN-PRO-25-00015





THE ALL-NEW HECTOR

DESIGNED TO Surprise

REVOLUTIONARY PRICE STARTS AT

₹11.99* LAKH

ALL NEW

INTRODUCING SEGMENT-FIRST

i-SWIPE

—TOUCH GESTURE CONTROL—





2-FINGER GESTURE

to control AC temperature and fan speed.

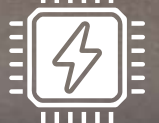


3-FINGER GESTURE

to change music tracks and adjust volume.



360° HD CAMERA WITH WHEEL VIEW



i-SMART

NOW WITH **SMART BOOST** (UPGRADED RAM)



AURA HEX GRILLE



AURA SCULPT BUMPERS



AURA BOLT ALLOY WHEELS



DUAL TONE URBAN TAN INTERIORS

COMPLETE OWNERSHIP ASSURANCE



3 YEARS UNLIMITED KM WARRANTY*
3 YEARS UNLIMITED KM ROADSIDE ASSISTANCE
3 FREE LABOUR SERVICES*



SCAN THE CODE TO BOOK YOUR TEST DRIVE

BOOK NOW ON **WWW.MGMOTOR.CO.IN** OR CALL **1800 100 6464**

*All prices are ex-showroom India. **In petrol and diesel segment. All variants showcased are top models. Vehicle body colour may differ due to the printing process. Images used in this ad are for representation purposes only. In view of our policy of continuously improving our products, we reserve the right to alter specifications, features and designs without prior notice and without liability. All variants are subject to availability. Please check details with your nearest MG dealership for the latest information. Accessories and features shown in the pictures may not be a part of standard equipment and will differ according to the variant. Available in select cities. *For commercial use cars, coverage up to 3 year/1 lakh km. The warranty coverage for 12V/48V battery, tyres is valid for 1 year while for infotainment system it is valid for 3 years. T&C apply. **For the first 3 scheduled services.

Chennai: MG Chennai Ambattur (08037080866), MG Chennai Anna Salai (08037080865), MG Chennai Chrompet (08037080867), MG Chennai Mount Road (08037080906), MG Chennai OMR (08037080862), MG Chennai Poonamallee (08037080907) **Coimbatore:** MG Coimbatore Avinashi Road (08037080888), MG Coimbatore Mettupalayam Road (08037080903)



Cheil 31772/26

Not much heat on this one



Mini Anthikad Chhibber
mini.chhibber@thehindu.co.in

As part from learning a new word, zugzwang (yet another apt German word, meaning “compulsion to move”) Courtney A. Kemp’s latest effort, *Nemesis*, does not make for particularly engaging viewing. There is a certain burnished Netflix-isation that has sanded away every bump and bulge to present a strangely anaemic show despite all the guns, knives, double and triple crosses. Everything seems to project seriousness and grit, with the actors all squinting dangerously while biting off ridiculous dialogue.

Nemesis is a lovely-looking show, where everyone is immaculately coifed and dressed while moving slinkily through deliciously lit-up homes in terribly impractical but eye-wateringly glamorous heels and nails.

The story offers nothing new. Detective Isaiah Stiles (Matthew Law), a Lieutenant in the LAPD’s Robbery-Homicide Division, is obsessed with bringing Coltrane Wilder (Y’lan Noel) down.

Coltrane seems to be the very pillar of respectability, a successful businessman who has moved away from his criminal past to make good. Isaiah naturally knows different. After his partner died in his arms during an armed robbery two years ago, Isaiah is hell-bent on bringing Coltrane to justice.

His marriage has suffered due to his obsession, and his wife, Candice (Gabrielle Dennis), wonders what happened to the man she married while moving closer to her college friend Malik (Jeff Pierre), who now works in the DA’s office. The couple is on a trial separation.

Isaiah’s unconventional approach to all things Coltrane has alienated everyone around him, including his son, Noah (Cedric Joe), his partner, Yvette (Ariana Guerra), and his boss, Captain James Sealey (Michael Potts). Isaiah has a difficult relationship with his father, Amos (Moe Irvin), a feared gangster from the old days.

Coltrane, on the other hand, is happily married to Ebony (Cleopatra Coleman), is in business with Ebony’s sister, Charlie (Sophina Brown) and has a tight friend circle comprising Stro (Tre Hale), Choi (Jonnie Park) and Deon (Quincy Isaiah). It also helps that they are part of Coltrane’s crew, responsible for all the high-stakes robberies around Los Angeles.

After an audacious robbery on Halloween, Isaiah is convinced he can nail Coltrane Through eight episodes of flying bullets, dirty cops, cartel capos with accents dodgier than their crimes, adultery, pregnancies and a fair bit of hectic acting, we are no nearer a resolution.

Nemesis’ hurry-up and wait approach is annoying, but you can always pass the time looking at elegantly cut trousers or that perfectly manicured talon typing out a mysterious text while Isaiah goes ballistic one more time.

Nemesis is currently streaming on Netflix.

An enjoyable action comedy

Nainu Oommen
nainu.oommen@thehindu.co.in

In the trailer of the Basil Joseph-starrer *Athiradi* by debutante Arun Anirudhan, the protagonist’s confidante Prashant Raj aka Parashu, played by Shelvin James, dismisses his ambitions to bring back a suspended college festival by telling him, “Are you Jagannathan to recommence a fest,” an allusion to Mohanlal’s character in *Aaram Thampuran*, released in 1997.

However, Basil’s Sam Kutty is different from the protagonist of the Shaji Kailas-film by miles. Sam’s attempted heroics are reduced to mere antics, making him a laughing stock in the BCET college, where the story is set. His self-inflated, larger-than-life image rarely translates to anything worth cheering for. But this characterisation is at the centre of what makes *Athiradi* an enjoyable



watch, despite being a formulaic story of an underdog finally proving his mettle.

The film, penned by Arun, who is the co-writer of *Minnal Murali*, and Paulson Skaria, known for *Kaathal - The Core*, begins with a tragic incident taking place during the college festival, Arohan, two years ago. Sam’s brother, Joseph aka Joppan, played by Vishnu Agasthya, was the convener of the celebration and considers himself accountable for the mishap. Sam’s sole objective

behind joining for the four-year BTEch course is to restart the annual fete at college, which would help his brother find closure.

But Sam’s aspirations to have a smooth running of the fete are spoiled by Sreekuttan Vellayani, a goon-turned-musician, played by Tovino Thomas.

At its core, *Athiradi*, produced by Basil and Dr Ananthu S, is a tale of conflicting male egos joining the list of films such as *Ayyappanum Koshiyum* directed by Sachy and

Driving License. by Lal Jr. Both Sreekuttan and Sam are driven by the love for their families, consumed by the thought of redemption.

During its 157-minute run-time, the film continues to create set-ups in the form of plot points and characters with satisfying payoffs. The film hinges on humour teeming with references to Gen Z culture, which works in most parts. With mentions about social media personalities and their online persona, *Athiradi* utilises meta references to some extent for humour.

While Basil’s over-the-top performance in the initial few sequences appear jarring, the character soon finds its rhythm, excelling in serious and comedic situations alike. The actor puts up a convincing act as the lovable goof, despite playing a role that is younger than his actual age. His chemistry with Shelvin is a joy to watch.

Tovino as Sreekuttan, a “musical goon”, as described by one of the characters in the film, steals the show with his slightly eccentric characterisation. He nails the

Thiruvananthapuram slang in his dialogue delivery and has a dominating screen presence throughout.

Vineeth Sreenivasan shines in an extended cameo with music director Shaan Rahman, playing themselves. Shaan is presented as a loud character, which aligns with the film’s treatment. Jeo Baby and Zarin Shihab play their parts well. Vishnu explores guilt, sadness, and redemption in his restrained performance as Joppan.

Athiradi

Director: Arun Anirudhan

Cast: Basil Joseph, Tovino Thomas, Vineeth Sreenivasan, Vishnu Agasthya, Shelvin James

Storyline: Sam Kutty’s attempts to revive a college fest hits a roadblock as he encounters a goon-turned-musician

The film feels fast-paced, moving from one highlight to another. Vishnu Vijay’s background score, especially in the scenes featuring Tovino, was top-notch. The action sequences in the film are well choreographed and a delight to watch.

However, Riya Shibu’s character, Swathy, remains underutilised with no other significant female characters in the film. The romance angle between Sam and Swathy seemed unnecessary for the film’s central plot.

Athiradi constantly turns to references to create laughter. So, understanding the jokes is primarily dependent on understanding these references, which exposes a weakness in the film’s writing.

Overall, *Athiradi* is a fun watch, which doesn’t take itself too seriously. The film consistently makes you laugh (if you catch the references) and recreates the vibes of a loud, energetic college fete.

Athiradi is currently running in theatres.



Suriya enters ‘God Mode’

Karuppu works best when RJ Balaji grounds Suriya’s ‘saamy padam’ in the emotional wreckage of a corrupt legal system

Bhuvanesh Chandar
bhuvanesh.chandar@thehindu.co.in

Once knew of a man who spent decades of energy, time, and money climbing the stairs of courts in a prolonged fight for justice. It was supposed to be a rather simple case surrounding a piece of land. Hope kept his fight alive. Belief in God and the justice system stood with him. To him, the legal struggle almost defined his life. But it is nothing special when you realise that you would find someone like him on every other street in our nation, dragged through the murk for decades.

When the man-made judicial system eventually tests its willpower, these victims would turn to God, hoping the powers that be would intervene and fight the corruption. Now, what if the unthinkable happened for real? What if God, say, the Karuppu Saamy, who millions of Tamil Hindus have prayed to for aeons, appears before his disciples and fights against the injustice that transpires in the court of law? This is the vibrant and potent setting of Suriya’s latest film, *Karuppu*, directed by RJ Balaji – a heady supernatural action drama initially powered by a strong emotional core.

It has been a rather dramatic couple of days for fans of actor Suriya. The very release of the film spiralled into a controversy, with everyone – even Balaji – turning to Lord Karuppu to sort out the issues. And now, *Karuppu* is finally here, and I am happy to report that this is the mass masala film Suriya fans have been waiting for. It features Suriya in a never-before-seen avatar and offers endless fan service through callbacks to the star’s filmography.

The story of *Karuppu*, too, begins with a prayer – from two innocent robbery victims, Binu (Anagha Maya Ravi) and her father (Indrans), who run into an obstacle that forever changes their lives. Baby Kannan (Balaji) is an unscrupulous and vulturous lawyer who operates the Seven Wells district court with an iron fist. It is a kangaroo court that swallows anyone who

Karuppu

Director: RJ Balaji

Cast: Suriya, Trisha, RJ Balaji, Indrans, Anagha Maya Ravi, Sshivada

Storyline: When a corrupt courtroom destroys the lives of ordinary people, Lord Karuppu descends as a lawyer to battle a predatory legal system and deliver justice to the oppressed.

tries to change the order set by Kannan, like Kanmani (Sshivada), who is fighting a sexual harassment case against her former employee and central minister, VM Pandian, a powerful man who has Kannan in his pocket. Meanwhile, Binu and her father employ Kannan’s services to retrieve their stolen jewels from the local police station.

The clock is ticking because these are the jewels that are needed to fund Binu’s critical liver transplant surgery. However, to the disbelief of the two, Kannan and his gang ensure the case keeps getting adjourned, while they exploit them. When all hope runs out, Binu’s father prays to Lord Karuppan at a temple in the court – and thus it begins. Karuppu (Suriya) leaves his red-hued hellish abode and comes to Seven Wells, threatening to finish Baby Kannan. But that is not a fair war, isn’t it? The film would cease to exist if a literal God just killed the human villain. Accepting the challenge of his foe, Karuppu appears as Sarvanan (also Suriya), a lawyer who vows to seek justice for Binu, and through her case, upend Kannan’s predatory establishment

Right off the bat, there are quite a few nuggets of ideas that ground the film; in the beginning, we see Binu courteously offering her seat in the courtroom to an elderly woman on multiple occasions. However, when she is made to repeatedly appear in court, she loses herself in the process and stops offering the woman a seat – a tiny arc that shows how courtrooms could break people and turn them into unkind beings.

While these ideas keep the film grounded to its reality, the problem with *Karuppu* begins when it veers from this potent emotional core after a point. Sure, the scenes that show Suriya in ‘God mode’ are fun to watch, but the emotional scaffolding begins to wither away, especially after the terrific intermission block. As a major hiccup, the film doesn’t clearly establish and maintain the rules of its supernatural entity, resorting to them as and when the plot progresses. Also, why must an omnipotent God of Justice fight for a man-made justice system created less than a century ago? Also, why does Karuppan choose to come now, through Binu’s case, while we clearly saw



Scan the QR Code for more entertainment news.

many others before Binu’s father offering prayers at the temple?

There are logical slips that you are asked to forgive – like henchmen who purposely run after a God as if their sickles would be enough to bring down a deity. The Karuppu character, too, seems to lack a dimension or two, as you never see him beyond spewing punchlines or innovatively sending men flying in the air. The ‘God Mode’ and ‘Raathu Raasan’ tracks, and their dance choreographies, hinted at what a more natural, more ‘humanised’ version of Karuppu could have felt like – I thought of the popular line from *Varuthapadatha Valibar Sangam* that goes “*Karuppan kusumbu kaaran*” – but the plot hardly allows for such moments.

It also seems like, after a point, Balaji and his team of writers have struggled to propel the plot forward, with Karuppu and his powers becoming a God-sized problem at the centre of the plot. It irks to see Trisha’s character, lawyer Preethi, serve little purpose beyond decoration. Meanwhile, though Sai Abhyankkar’s songs with Balaji’s picturisation fit this modern take on a ‘*saamy padam*,’ his scores do appear to distract one from the proceedings. But then, even through all these pitfalls, what really makes *Karuppu* a fun entertainer is the sheer control of the frame that Suriya exhibits and the goodness in Balaji’s morality tale. This is a story of hope, and hope is always a good thing.

Remember the old man I mentioned who fought a case for over three decades? After his demise, his son began chasing the suits and climbing up the stairs of the courts. And today, while watching *Karuppu*, that son imagined what his father would have fantasised while praying to the many Gods. And for two odd hours, the atheist in him vanished, willingly. I don’t know if God could fight for justice. But *Karuppu* – even while being a shallow fanfare entertainer – could still instil hope and positivity. And perhaps that’s the real victory of the film. And in its own twisted way, perhaps that is still worth every penny. Just God things.

Karuppu is currently running in theatres.

Hokum

Director: Damian McCarthy

Cast: Adam Scott, Peter Coonan, David Wilmot, Florence Ordesch, Michael Patric, Will O’Connell, Brendan Conroy, Austin Amelio

Storyline: When novelist Ohm Bauman retreats to a remote inn to scatter his parents’ ashes, he’s consumed by tales of a witch that haunts the honeymoon suite



Nasty little ghost story

English

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury
ayaan.paul@thehindu.co.in

For those of you already familiar with Damian McCarthy’s work, the Irish filmmaker has spent the past few years turning cramped Irish spaces into elaborate, nerve-racking machines for dread. His latest, *Hokum*, pushes that approach into a larger setting without sacrificing the intimate unpleasantness that makes his work so effective. The film takes place almost entirely inside the Bilberry Woods Hotel, a fading property buried in the Irish countryside

where the final few guests arrive for a Halloween celebration. At the same time, staff members quietly prepare to shut the building down for winter. Into this atmosphere walks Ohm Bauman, played by Adam Scott, an American novelist carrying two urns containing his parents’ ashes and a personality abrasive enough to make even the resident ghouls feel hospitable. The opening sequence shows him writing the conclusion to a historical adventure novel about a conquistador stranded in the desert with a dying child, and the scene initially appears disconnected from the main story until the camera pulls back to reveal that the entire episode exists inside Ohm’s manuscript. This intro establishes the emotional logic driving the film. Ohm writes stories where people wander toward death because he has spent most of his adult life emotionally entombed inside the loss of his parents, who died shortly after honeymooning at the same Irish hotel he now visits. McCarthy avoids turning this into a tidy psychological diagnosis and attempts to reveal the damage through behaviour.

That ugliness becomes central to Scott’s performance. *Hokum* strips away the comic cushioning that often softens his cynicism. Scott keeps Ohm emotionally rigid even as the character begins to unravel inside the hotel’s sealed honeymoon suite, and the refusal to chase sympathy lends the film a sourness that works in its favour. When Ohm eventually risks himself to search for the hotel bartender Fiona, the motivation grows from guilt and loneliness over his botched suicide attempt. Fiona disappears after warning him about the suite’s resident witch, and her absence pushes Ohm deeper into the building’s sinister secrets. The film loses some momentum once McCarthy begins unpacking the mystery behind Fiona’s disappearance and the crimes attached to the hotel’s past. Several supporting characters remain thinly drawn, particularly the hotel management, and the screenplay occasionally mistakes withholding information for complexity. The final stretch also leans too heavily on explanatory reveals and heightened confrontations, with the climactic

encounter involving the witch pushing the film toward bluntness when the earlier sections had earned their power through suggestion alone. Even so, *Hokum* succeeds because McCarthy understands the mechanical pleasures of horror filmmaking at a level many contemporary prestige directors seem embarrassed by. Though the scares land with diminishing returns this time, McCarthy still stages them with the acute understanding of just how long we will stare into a dark hallway before resenting ourselves for it. His folklore imagery still carries the grubby charm of an R.L. Stine paperback pulled from a damp school library shelf, which gives the film a pulpy nastiness that suits it well. McCarthy never fully organises many of these elements into a clean mythology. What he does create is a horror film with texture and personality, even if it barely holds up against the mastery of its predecessors.

Hokum is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Kritika Kamra to headline upcoming drama film titled Dumbbell

Actor Kritika Kamra will be headlining the upcoming drama film, tentatively titled *Dumbbell*, which marks the directorial debut of Pushaan Mukherjee, known for serving as the assistant director in films like *Kapoor & Sons* and *Jab Harry Met Sejal*. As per a press release, the film’s shooting is set to commence in June and Kritika has started preparing for the role, which has been described as “both physically and emotionally demanding”. More details about the film are awaited. Meanwhile, Kritika was last seen in Vijay Varma’s period-drama series, *Matka King*, which was released last month.



Rajkumar Hirani’s comedy-drama series sets release date

Rajkumar Hirani will be making his streaming debut with the upcoming JioHotstar series, *Pritam and Pedro*, the streamer announced on May 19. It will be released on JioHotstar on July 3. Created and produced by Hirani, the series has been directed by Avinash Arun, known for helming the Marathi film *Killa* and the second season of *Paatal Lok*. As per a press release shared by the makers, the series centers around the story of two men standing beside an abandoned ATM machine on a beach, blending “warmth, emotion and human storytelling”. More details about the cast from the show are awaited.



Kunal Kemmu’s action-comedy gets theatrical release date

Vibe, Kunal Kemmu’s second directorial after *Madgaon Express*, has a theatrical release date. The film, written and directed by Kemmu and also featuring him in the lead, will be released in theatres on September 18. The film also stars Preity Zinta, Sparsh Shrivastava, and Vanshika Dhir in pivotal roles. As per a press release, “The film tells the story of two inseparable friends whose ordinary, unassuming lives spiral into an unpredictable, high-energy adventure that pushes their survival instincts and friendship to the limit.” It is produced by Kemmu and Chirag Nihalani under the banner of Drongo Films.



A charming Hockey romance

Prime Video’s *Off Campus*, is a predictable, glossy hockey romance elevated by strong chemistry, emotional sincerity, and an excellent soundtrack

English

Sangita Rajan
sangitarajan.pb@thehindu.co.in

It is the season for hockey romances. Or has it always been? The genre has long had a devoted readership even before *Heated Rivalry* began appearing on every bookstore display, because evidently, hockey players are attractive, emotionally unavailable, deeply competitive, and therefore perfect romance material. Prime Video’s *Off Campus*, based on *The Deal* by Elle Kennedy (which predates all of the *Game Changers* books), is, in simple words, a fun Sunday watch and a welcome distraction from both the news cycle and life itself. The first season follows star centre hockey player Garrett Graham (Belmont Cameli) and musical composition major Hannah Wells (Ella Bright). Garrett’s GPA is plummeting, threatening both his place on the team and his future hockey career. Hannah, meanwhile, wants help catching the attention of her rockstar-musician crush Justin (Josh Heuston). A mutually beneficial arrangement is struck: she tutors him, he helps make her excruciatingly attractive to another man, and naturally, the fake-dating trope begins to unfold exactly as expected. *Off Campus* understands precisely what it wants to be. It does not attempt prestige television, nor does it pretend to reinvent the romance genre. Instead, it leans fully into yearning glances, locker-room banter, emotionally unavailable frat boys, and the kind of chemistry that thrives on prolonged denial and a plenty of spicy montages. One of the series’ greatest surprises, however, is its music. Hannah being a student composer does not feel like a throwaway character detail inserted to make her seem interesting. The show

Off Campus

Creators: Gina Fattore, Louisa Levy

Episodes: 8

Storyline: A music major and a star college hockey player strike a tutoring deal so she can make her crush jealous, but their “practice” romance quickly develops into something real.

actively builds its emotional rhythm around sound. The soundtrack moves fluidly from The Beaches to The Black Keys, from AC/DC to Billy Idol, creating a soundscape that feels both nostalgic and sharply curated. In one scene, Hannah, trying to pull herself out of a creative and emotional funk, wanders into the theatre green room and begins playing Elton John’s “The Bitch Is Back” on the piano. What begins as a quiet attempt to distract herself slowly turns into singing, dancing, and a complete release of frustration. On ice, Garrett is spiralling through an awful game and during half-time, he catches sight of Hannah through the theatre door and her energy, ridiculousness, and complete abandon pull him out of his own head and back into the game. More than once, the soundtrack becomes distracting in the best possible sense, making you reach for your phone to see whether someone has already assembled a Spotify playlist of the series. They have. You are welcome. Beneath all the flirting, banter, and hockey-player chaos, the series also makes space for heavier themes. Garrett grows up under the shadow of an abusive father, a former hockey star, and that upbringing shapes his fears of becoming violent, aggressive and emotionally closed off. After one ugly incident on the ice, he begins questioning not just the kind of player he wants to be, but the kind of man. Hannah, meanwhile, is dealing with the aftermath of sexual assault, something she keeps hidden out of fear that people will begin seeing her differently. That trauma affects her songwriting, and relationship with sex and vulnerability. The handling is not always perfect, and some emotional beats feel rushed, but there is enough sincerity here to give the series emotional weight beneath all its easy charm. There are also moments when the series teaches consent better than any sex education class. Clear communication, respecting boundaries and trust are shown not just as important but attractive.

The ensemble cast does much of the heavy lifting when it comes to capturing the chaotic, magnetic energy of the series. Dean Di Laurentis (Stephen Kalyn) and Allie Hayes (Mika Abdalla) have undeniable chemistry even in the limited moments they share this season, making it very easy to see why audiences are already eager for them to take centre stage in upcoming seasons. Antonio Cipriano’s John Logan, Garrett’s best friend and right-hand man on the team, emerges as one of the show’s most lovable characters. Scrappy, hardworking, and emotionally transparent in ways Garrett often is not, Logan brings warmth to the series without feeling reduced to just the protagonist’s best friend. The reason this show works as well as it does is not just because the characters are socially aware (despite being college frat boys and girls), but because the characters remind us of some iconic and classic characters from the early 90s and 2000s. Belmont Cameli’s Garrett Graham feels almost identical to Heath Ledger’s Patrick Verona from *10 Things I Hate About You*, not just in the curly locks and dashing smile, but also in mannerisms. Milo Ventimiglia’s Jess Mariano from *Gilmore Girls* walked so John Logan could run. Troubled lover boy, yearning looks, smart and witty, is so very Jess coded, and this is not just me connecting dots where they do not exist. Showrunner Louisa Levy, in an interview, said that the show has several nods to early 2000s romcoms like *Sixteen Candles* and *10 Things I Hate About You*. The show stands firmly on its own, making it easy to get swept up in the romance, chemistry, and emotional chaos without any prior attachment to the books. Nevertheless, I am now debating whether to read the next book before the new season drops or simply surrender to the algorithm flooding my feed with edits, interviews, fan theories, and memes while the soundtrack plays in the background. Life, for now, can wait.

Off Campus is now streaming on Prime Video